

THE AMULETT

A Scaretale Film
Birmingham, 1970s

Treatment & Act Structure

Controlling Idea

A man who treats love as a resource discovers, too late, that the only love worth having was the one that required him to be nothing other than himself.

Birmingham, 1973. Cold in every sense — economically, climatically, emotionally. The factories are closing. The city is asking the same question as the man at its centre: what have I become, and is it too late?

Thesis

The wound

THOMAS, late 30s, is a man shaped by a series of quiet abandonments — people he left before they could leave him. The most significant is SARAH, a woman who saw him clearly and loved him anyway, whom he let go because being truly seen felt more dangerous than being alone. The film opens years after Sarah. Thomas is greying, recently left by another woman, staring at a bathroom mirror in a bedsit off the Hagley Road. The grey in his beard is not vanity. It is a clock.

The object

The amulett is found, not sought. It has no mythology, no origin, no explanation. It is small, unremarkable, cold to the touch even in a warm hand. Thomas discovers its function accidentally: proximity to another person, sustained, transfers something from them to him — vitality, time, life-force. They wake the next morning with new aches, small lines. He wakes lighter. He does not question it for long. He is desperate and the amulett offers a door.

The wish

The film's hinge arrives when Thomas, drunk on borrowed youth and the first genuine happiness he has felt in years, makes his demand of the amulett directly. He wants this to last. He wants every day to feel as full and consequential as it did when he was young, when everything was still possible, when Sarah was still there.

He says: "Let me taste every day like a year."

The amulett grants it. Literally. Precisely. From that night forward, Thomas ages one year per day.

The amulett does not misunderstand him. It understands him perfectly — and gives him exactly what he asked for, stripped of every assumption he wrapped around the asking. He wanted presence. He wanted the feeling of time mattering. Now every day matters. Now every day costs.

The moral argument

The horror of *The Amulett* is not supernatural. It is ethical. Thomas does not become a monster — he becomes a recognisable human failure, accelerated. Each sin he moves through feels, to him, like a solution. Pride feels like confidence recovered. Greed feels like finally claiming what he deserves. Lust feels like proof he is still alive. The audience sees the decay. He sees progress. That gap is the film's engine.

The killing of SUSIE — the second woman, the surface love — is not a villain moment. It is grief wearing the mask of violence. She was the last person alive who saw him as young and vital. Her leaving means that version of him has no witness left. He does not kill from hatred. He kills to prevent the confirmation of what he already knows.

Sarah would have stayed. Sarah knew what was underneath. The film's final image holds that truth without stating it: Thomas, alone, ageing visibly, with a trace of Sarah somewhere in the room — a letter, a voice, a photograph — and the understanding that the amulett could never give back what it never had the power to take. That was always his to lose.

Act Structure

Act One — The Mirror

Birmingham. Winter. A city in economic contraction. The personal and the political rhyme without explanation.

SCENE 1 — THE BATHROOM, EARLY MORNING

Thomas stands at a small bathroom mirror. The light is cold fluorescent. He examines a grey hair in his beard — then another. He trims it. Then trims more. Then shaves it entirely. He stares at the unfamiliar face beneath. Younger, almost. But the eyes are the same.

Tone: quiet, almost mundane. No music. The horror here is recognition, not spectacle.

SCENE 2 — THE CITY

Thomas moves through Birmingham. Factory gates. A pub lunch eaten alone. A conversation with a colleague who mentions a woman — someone from Thomas's past, obliquely. The city is cold. There is a power cut mid-afternoon. Thomas walks home in the dark.

Establish: the economic cold mirrors the personal. Birmingham is not backdrop — it is rhyme.

SCENE 3 — THE BEDSIT, NIGHT

Thomas finds the amulett in a drawer he is clearing out. He almost throws it away. Something stops him. It is cold in his hand even though the room is warm. He puts it on the windowsill and goes to bed.

SCENE 4 — FIRST CONTACT (ACCIDENTAL)

Thomas falls asleep on a bus beside an elderly man. He wakes feeling inexplicably well — rested, clear-headed, almost young. The man beside him is rubbing his wrist, frowning at a new ache. Thomas thinks nothing of it. He is almost smiling.

The audience understands before Thomas does. This is the contract the film makes with the viewer: we know what he doesn't, yet.

SCENE 5 — UNDERSTANDING

Thomas tests it. Deliberately, cautiously, with strangers. A woman on a bench. A man at the bar. Each time: he gains, they lose, subtly. He watches. He reasons. He decides. The decision is quiet and efficient and the film does not dramatise it into a crisis. He needs this. He takes it.

Critical: no dramatic music. No horror cue. The decision to steal from strangers must feel like a practical choice — that is the moral indictment.

Act Two (Part One) — The Retreat

Thomas, younger-feeling, more vital, enters a new relationship. SARAH is glimpsed in a photograph, a half-finished letter, a voicemail he has never deleted — present in absence throughout.

SCENE 6 — MEETING SUSIE

Thomas meets SUSIE at a social gathering — a friend's flat, cheap wine, a record playing. He is charming in a way he has not been in years. She is attracted to the vitality, the attention, the focus. He is genuinely happy. This is important: the happiness is real. The film does not ask us to distrust it yet.

SCENE 7 — THE COUNTRY RETREAT

They go to a borrowed cottage in the Worcestershire countryside. Snow on the ground. A coal fire. For a time, it is genuinely good. Thomas uses the amulett minimally — a stranger at a pub, a farmer at a gate. Small thefts. Manageable.

The retreat isolates them. This is not incidental — it is structural. No strangers means only Susie can feed the amulett. Thomas does not make this choice yet. The situation is making it for him.

SCENE 8 — THE TURN

Thomas wakes at 3am. He is ageing slightly — the wish has not yet been spoken, but the amulett is beginning to demand. He looks at Susie sleeping. She is the only source available. He watches her for a long time. Then he takes her hand.

She wakes briefly. He says he couldn't sleep. She goes back to sleep. He stays awake, holding her hand, and the fire burns down, and the room gets cold.

The film's moral centre. This is not a monster moment. It is a quiet, almost tender theft — and that is what makes it unbearable.

SCENE 9 — DEPTH REPLACED BY SURFACE

Over subsequent days, the connection shifts. Thomas stops listening and starts performing. Susie feels it but cannot name it. She becomes a mirror he holds up to reassure himself rather than a person he is present with. She begins to withdraw. He pursues more aggressively — not from love but from need. The theft continues nightly.

The Wish — The Film's Hinge

SCENE 10 — THE WISH SPOKEN

Night. Thomas alone by the window, the amulett in his hand. Susie is asleep. He is aware, somewhere beneath the performance, that this is slipping away. He holds the amulett and says the words — not as a command but as a plea. Desperate and precise and fatal.

"Let me taste every day like a year."

The amulett does not respond visibly. There is no flash, no sound. The room is the same. Thomas goes to bed.

The next morning he is noticeably older. Not dramatically — just undeniably. A decade in his face. He does not understand it yet.

The horror here is administrative. The amulett fulfilled the contract. It always does.

Act Two (Part Two) — The Clock

Thomas ages one year per day. He tries to hide it. He cannot. Time, which he wanted to taste fully, is now visible on his skin.

SCENE 11 — ACCELERATION

A sequence of days, each one a year. Thomas moves from his 40s to his 50s to his 60s in a week. He buys hair dye. It washes out. He tries to dress younger. He looks worse. He is frantic, charming, desperate in equal measure. Susie watches with growing unease.

This sequence should be almost darkly comic before it becomes horrifying. Birmingham goes on around him — buses, markets, people with ordinary lives — indifferent to his acceleration.

SCENE 12 — SUSIE LEAVES

Susie does not leave in a dramatic scene. She is simply not there one morning. A note that explains nothing adequately. She saw something she could not name and could not stay beside. She is not cruel. She is frightened.

Thomas reads the note. He reads it twice. He folds it carefully and puts it in his pocket.

Play the objective: he is not trying to be devastated. He is trying to understand how to survive this. The devastation is in the stillness.

SCENE 13 — THE DECISION

Thomas finds Susie. This is not presented as a chase or a horror set-piece. It is methodical and quiet. He believes — genuinely, terribly — that if she is gone there is no witness left to the version of himself the amulett gave him. He cannot bear to be the only one who remembers it.

SCENE 14 — THE KILLING

The killing is not shown in full. A room. A confrontation. The sound of something ending. Thomas stands alone afterwards, much older now, in a room that is very quiet. He looks at his hands. He puts them in his pockets.

Moss's note: do not play the horror. Play the silence of a man who has just done the most human thing in the worst possible way. The emotion, if it comes, comes later and offscreen.

Act Three — What Remains

SCENE 15 — THE AMULETT IS GONE

Thomas returns to the bedsit. He searches for the amulett. It is not there. He searches again. He upends the room. It is gone — lost somewhere in the days of acceleration, or taken, or simply done with him. He sits on the floor of the upended room. He is very old.

SCENE 16 — SARAH

Thomas finds, in the debris of the room, the voicemail he never deleted. He plays it. Sarah's voice — recorded years ago, before everything. She is asking if he wants to get dinner. It is an ordinary message. It is the most terrible thing in the film.

He plays it again.

The film does not tell us what Sarah represents. The audience has understood for some time.

SCENE 17 — BIRMINGHAM, MORNING

Thomas outside. Birmingham waking up. He is old in a city that is also ageing, also asking what it has become. He walks. The film does not resolve him. He is simply present, in the cold, in the city, with whatever years are left — and the understanding that the amulett could not give him what he actually needed, because what he actually needed required nothing more than choosing it.

Final image: Thomas walking away down a street, growing smaller. The city indifferent. The morning light cold and flat and true.

FADE TO BLACK.

Production Notes

SETTING

1970s Birmingham is not backdrop — it is argument. The three-day week, power cuts, factory closures: a city also asking what it has become after squandering what it had. The economic cold and the climatic cold are the same cold. Shoot in actual Birmingham. Use the industrial architecture as moral landscape.

TONE

Not Dorian Gray. The amulett is never explained, never decorated, never mythologised. It is a small found object in a drawer. The horror is not supernatural spectacle — it is the quiet, recognisable machinery of a man destroying himself through choices that each feel, in the moment, like survival.

BUDGET DISCIPLINE

Scaretales model. The horror here requires exceptional performance, a period-accurate location, and nothing else. No special effects budget required for the ageing — practical makeup, time-cuts, and a committed actor. This is a film that works harder the less it shows.

THE AMULETT ON SCREEN

Small. Undecorated. Cold. Never glowing, never pulsing. The camera should not linger on it. It should be easy to miss in the frame — because missing it is how Thomas got into this.

SARAH

Sarah is never seen clearly. A photograph from behind. A handwriting on an envelope. A voice on a tape. Her presence is felt as an absence throughout. She is what the film is about and she must never be reduced to an explanation.

CONTROLLING IDEA (RESTATED)

A man who treats love as a resource discovers, too late, that the only love worth having was the one that required him to be nothing other than himself.